

Practical AI Skills

A Beginner-Friendly Guide

Learn to use AI tools for everyday tasks — no coding required

What you will learn in this guide:

1. Creating Images for Presentations
2. Building Presentations from Scratch
3. Fetching and Organizing Data
4. Writing Emails and Messages
5. Summarizing Documents
6. Simple Automation Ideas
7. Learning and Research Assistance
8. Tips for Writing Better Prompts

Introduction

Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools like ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot, and Gemini can help you accomplish everyday tasks faster and with better results. You don't need to be a programmer or a tech expert to use them — you just need to learn how to ask the right questions.

This guide provides practical, real-world examples of things you can do with AI right now. Each example includes the exact prompt (the instruction you type into the AI) so you can copy it, adapt it, and start using it immediately.

How to use this guide: Each section covers a different use case. For every example, you'll find a **Prompt Box** — this is the text you type (or paste) into the AI tool. Below each prompt, there's an explanation of why it works and what to expect.

Tip: You can use these prompts with most AI assistants: Claude (claude.ai), ChatGPT (chat.openai.com), Microsoft Copilot, or Google Gemini. Some features may vary between tools.

1. Creating Images for Presentations

AI image generators can create custom illustrations, diagrams, icons, and visuals for your presentations in seconds. No need to spend time searching for stock photos that almost fit — just describe what you want.

Popular tools for image generation include DALL-E (inside ChatGPT), Microsoft Designer, Adobe Firefly, and Midjourney.

Example 1.1: A Cover Image for a Presentation

 Prompt:
<i>Create a professional, clean illustration for a presentation cover slide about cybersecurity awareness in the workplace. Use a modern flat design style with blue and white tones. Show a shield icon protecting a laptop, with subtle lock and network symbols in the background. No text in the image.</i>
Why it works: The prompt specifies the style (flat design), colors (blue and white), subject matter (cybersecurity), composition (shield + laptop), and explicitly asks for no text — which keeps the image versatile.

Example 1.2: An Icon Set for Slides

 Prompt:
<i>Generate a set of 4 simple, flat-style icons for a business presentation: (1) a handshake for partnerships, (2) a lightbulb for innovation, (3) a bar chart going up for growth, (4) a target with an arrow for goals. Use a consistent style with navy blue as the main color on a transparent or white background.</i>
Why it works: Asking for consistent style and color ensures the icons look like they belong together on your slides.

Example 1.3: A Process Diagram Illustration

 Prompt:
<i>Create a simple visual showing a 4-step process flow: Step 1 'Identify' → Step 2 'Analyze' → Step 3 'Implement' → Step 4 'Review'. Use rounded boxes connected by arrows, with a clean corporate style, using green and gray tones.</i>
Why it works: Describing the exact layout (boxes, arrows, labels) gives the AI a clear visual structure to follow.

Tip: Always specify “no text” if you want a clean image, or provide the exact text you want. AI image tools sometimes produce garbled or misspelled words.

2. Building Presentations from Scratch

AI can help you structure, outline, and even draft entire presentations. You provide the topic and audience, and the AI gives you a complete outline with slide content, speaker notes, and suggestions.

Example 2.1: Full Presentation Outline

 Prompt:
<i>Create a 10-slide presentation outline about 'Remote Work Best Practices' for a team of office managers who are not very technical. For each slide, provide: the slide title, 3-4 bullet points of content, and a suggestion for a visual or image. Keep the language simple and practical.</i>
Why it works: Specifying the audience (office managers, not technical), number of slides, and asking for visual suggestions gives you a complete, ready-to-build presentation plan.

Example 2.2: Speaker Notes for Existing Slides

 Prompt:
<i>I have a presentation about our quarterly sales results with these slides: 1) Revenue Overview, 2) Top Products, 3) Regional Performance, 4) Challenges, 5) Next Quarter Goals. Write speaker notes for each slide (about 4-5 sentences each) in a conversational, confident tone.</i>
Why it works: By providing your existing slide structure, the AI generates complementary notes that match your flow.

Example 2.3: Transforming a Document into a Presentation

 Prompt:
<i>I have a 2-page report about our company's sustainability initiatives. Convert it into a 7-slide presentation. Extract the key points, simplify the language, and organize them into clear slides with short bullet points. Suggest a title for each slide. [Paste your report text below this prompt]</i>
Why it works: AI excels at restructuring long content into concise, visual-friendly formats.

Tip: After getting the outline from AI, you can ask follow-up questions like: "Make slide 3 more visual" or "Simplify the language on slide 5."

3. Fetching and Organizing Data

AI can help you collect, organize, summarize, and make sense of data. Whether you need to create a comparison table, extract info from a messy document, or generate sample data for testing, AI handles it with ease.

Example 3.1: Creating a Comparison Table

 Prompt:
<i>Create a comparison table of the top 5 project management tools (Asana, Trello, Monday.com, Jira, Notion). Compare them by: price (free plan available?), ease of use (beginner-friendly?), best for (small teams, enterprises, etc.), and key features. Format it as a clean table.</i>
Why it works: The prompt specifies exactly which tools and which comparison criteria, so the AI produces a structured, useful table.

Example 3.2: Extracting Information from Text

 Prompt:
<i>I'm going to paste a list of customer feedback comments below. Please analyze them and give me: (1) the top 3 most common complaints, (2) the top 3 most praised features, and (3) a brief summary of overall sentiment. Organize your answer with clear headings. [Paste feedback below]</i>
Why it works: Giving the AI a clear structure for the output (top complaints, top praises, summary) prevents vague answers.

Example 3.3: Generating Sample Data

 Prompt:
<i>Generate a sample spreadsheet dataset with 20 rows of fictional employee data. Include columns for: Name, Department (choose from Sales, Engineering, Marketing, HR), Start Date, Annual Salary (between 30000 and 90000), and Performance Rating (1-5). Format it as a CSV that I can paste into Excel.</i>
Why it works: Specifying the exact columns, ranges, and output format (CSV) gives you immediately usable data.

Tip: If you need to work with your own data, you can upload files (Excel, CSV, PDF) to some AI tools like Claude or ChatGPT, and ask the AI to analyze, clean, or transform the data for you.

4. Writing Emails and Messages

One of the most immediately useful things AI can do is help you write professional emails, messages, and communications. Whether you struggle with finding the right tone, translating your ideas into clear text, or just want to save time, AI is a great writing assistant.

Example 4.1: Professional Email Reply

 Prompt:

A client sent me an email complaining that their order arrived late and one item was damaged. Write a professional, empathetic reply that: (1) apologizes sincerely, (2) explains we'll send a replacement immediately, (3) offers a 15% discount on their next order, and (4) provides a support phone number (555-0123). Keep it under 150 words.

Why it works: Providing specific details (what happened, what you want to offer, the phone number) means the AI draft needs minimal editing.

Example 4.2: Meeting Follow-up Email

 Prompt:

Write a follow-up email after a project kickoff meeting. The attendees were the marketing team (5 people) and two external consultants. Key decisions made: (1) campaign launches March 15, (2) budget approved at €25,000, (3) Sarah is the project lead. Action items: Sarah will send the timeline by Friday, consultants will deliver the brand audit by March 1. Tone: friendly but professional.

Why it works: Including all the specifics (names, dates, amounts, decisions) lets the AI produce a complete, accurate email.

Example 4.3: Difficult Message

 Prompt:

Help me write a message to a colleague who has been consistently missing deadlines. I want to be direct but respectful. I don't want to be accusatory. The goal is to understand if they're having difficulties and offer support, while making clear that deadlines need to be met. Keep it warm but firm. This will be sent via Slack.

Why it works: Explaining the emotional context (direct but respectful, not accusatory) helps the AI calibrate the tone precisely.

Tip: Always review AI-generated emails before sending. Check for accuracy, add personal touches, and make sure the tone matches your relationship with the recipient.

5. Summarizing Documents and Content

AI is exceptionally good at reading long texts and producing concise summaries. This is perfect for long reports, articles, meeting transcripts, or any content you need to understand quickly.

Example 5.1: Summarize a Long Report

 Prompt:
<i>Summarize the following report in 3 parts: (1) A one-paragraph executive summary (max 5 sentences), (2) Key findings as a bullet list (max 7 items), (3) Recommended next steps. Use simple language suitable for a non-technical manager. [Paste report below]</i>
Why it works: A structured output request (executive summary + key findings + next steps) is more useful than just asking “summarize this.”

Example 5.2: Meeting Transcript to Action Items

 Prompt:
<i>Here is a transcript from a 45-minute team meeting. Please extract: (1) All decisions that were made, (2) All action items with the responsible person and deadline if mentioned, (3) Any unresolved questions or topics that need follow-up. Format each section clearly. [Paste transcript below]</i>
Why it works: This turns messy meeting notes into a clean, actionable summary that can be shared with the team.

Example 5.3: Simplify a Technical Document

 Prompt:
<i>I need to share this technical IT security policy with all employees, including non-technical staff. Rewrite it in plain, simple language. Avoid jargon. If a technical term must be used, explain it in parentheses. Keep the same structure and section headings. [Paste policy below]</i>
Why it works: Asking the AI to keep the structure but simplify the language means the output maps directly to the original for easy comparison.

6. Simple Automation Ideas

Even without coding skills, you can use AI to create simple scripts and automations. Many AI tools can generate ready-to-use formulas, scripts, or step-by-step instructions for automating repetitive tasks.

Example 6.1: Excel / Google Sheets Formulas

Prompt:

I have an Excel spreadsheet where column A has employee names, column B has their department, and column C has their sales numbers. I need a formula that: (1) Calculates the total sales for each department, (2) Highlights in red any employee with sales below 1000, (3) Creates a summary at the bottom with the average, minimum, and maximum sales. Please explain each formula step by step.

Why it works: Describing your spreadsheet layout and the exact results you want lets the AI give you formulas you can paste directly into your sheet.

Example 6.2: File Renaming Instructions

Prompt:

I have 200 photos with random names like IMG_3847.jpg, DSC_0012.jpg, etc. I want to rename them to a pattern like: Vacation_Portugal_001.jpg, Vacation_Portugal_002.jpg, and so on. Give me step-by-step instructions to do this on Windows without installing any software. If a simple script is needed, write it and tell me exactly how to run it.

Why it works: Specifying the operating system (Windows) and the constraint (no extra software) means the AI gives you a practical, immediately usable solution.

Example 6.3: Email Template Generator

Prompt:

I send the same type of email to new clients every week. The only things that change are: the client name, company name, meeting date, and meeting link. Create a template for Gmail where I just fill in those 4 fields. Also, give me a checklist of things to verify before sending each email.

Why it works: The AI understands the concept of variable fields and creates a reusable template, plus adds a quality-check step.

Tip: If you use Microsoft Power Automate or Zapier, you can ask AI to help you design automation workflows step by step: “Help me create a Zapier automation that saves Gmail attachments to Google Drive.”

7. Learning and Research Assistance

AI can serve as a patient, always-available tutor or research assistant. Whether you're trying to understand a new topic, learn a skill, or research a subject, AI adapts to your level and pace.

Example 7.1: Learning a New Concept

 Prompt:
<i>Explain what blockchain technology is as if I'm a 12-year-old. Use a real-world analogy. Then, give me 3 practical examples of how blockchain is used today outside of cryptocurrency. Keep it under 300 words.</i>
Why it works: "Explain like I'm 12" is a powerful technique that forces the AI to avoid jargon and use relatable examples.

Example 7.2: Research Summary

 Prompt:
<i>I need to prepare a short presentation on the benefits and risks of AI in healthcare. Give me: (1) 5 key benefits with a one-sentence explanation each, (2) 5 key risks with a one-sentence explanation each, (3) 3 real-world examples of AI being used in hospitals today. Cite any specific organizations or tools if you can.</i>
Why it works: Asking for specific counts (5 benefits, 5 risks, 3 examples) and real-world references produces focused, credible content.

Example 7.3: Study Plan

 Prompt:
<i>I want to learn basic data analysis using Excel. I have about 2 hours per week and I'm a complete beginner. Create a 4-week learning plan with: weekly goals, specific topics to cover, one practice exercise per week, and free resources (YouTube videos or websites) I can use. Keep it realistic for someone with no technical background.</i>
Why it works: Providing your constraints (2 hours/week, beginner, free resources) lets the AI create a genuinely personalized learning path.

8. Tips for Writing Better Prompts

The quality of AI output depends heavily on how you write your prompt. Here are the essential principles that will make your interactions with AI much more productive.

Principle	How to Apply It
Be Specific	Instead of “Write an email”, say “Write a professional email to a client apologizing for a delayed shipment, offering a 10% discount.”
Define Your Audience	Tell the AI who will read the output: “for non-technical managers”, “for a 10-year-old”, “for senior engineers.”
Set the Format	Ask for the structure you want: “as a bullet list”, “as a table”, “in 3 paragraphs”, “as a step-by-step guide.”
Give Context	Explain the situation: “I’m a small business owner, and I need...” or “This is for an internal presentation to 20 people.”
Set Constraints	Limit length (“under 200 words”), tone (“formal”, “casual”), or scope (“focus only on European regulations”).
Iterate and Refine	If the first answer isn’t perfect, ask follow-ups: “Make it shorter”, “Use simpler language”, “Add an example for point 3.”
Provide Examples	Show the AI what you want: “Here’s an example of the style I like: [paste example]. Now write something similar for...”
Assign a Role	Start with a role: “Act as a marketing expert”, “You are a patient teacher”, “Behave like a business consultant.”

The Quick Prompt Formula

When in doubt, use this simple structure for any prompt:

 Formula:
<code>[Role] + [Task] + [Context] + [Format] + [Constraints]</code>

Here’s an example putting it all together:

 Example using the formula:
<i>You are a professional copywriter [Role]. Write a product description [Task] for our new eco-friendly water bottle that we’re launching on our website next week [Context]. Write it as a short paragraph followed by 5 bullet points with key features [Format]. Keep it under 150 words and use an enthusiastic but not pushy tone [Constraints].</i>
Each piece gives the AI exactly what it needs to produce useful, targeted output on the first try.

Final Thoughts

AI is a powerful tool, but it works best when you think of it as a very capable assistant — not a magic button. The better you communicate what you need, the better results you'll get.

Start with the examples in this guide, adapt them to your own needs, and don't be afraid to experiment. The great thing about AI is that you can always try again — ask for changes, provide more detail, or approach the question differently.

Remember: there are no “wrong” prompts. Every interaction is a learning opportunity. The more you practice, the better you'll become at getting exactly what you need from AI tools.

Happy experimenting! 🚀

This guide was created with the help of AI — which is proof that anyone can do it.